

nels, Cyrus, with the first approach of the ensuing spring, marched forward against Babylon. The Babylonians, encamped without their walls, awaited his coming. A battle was fought at a short distance from the city, in which the Babylonians were defeated by the Persian king, whereupon they withdrew within their defences. Here they shut themselves up, and made light of his siege, having laid in a store of provisions for many years in preparation against this attack; for when they saw Cyrus conquering nation after nation, they were convinced that he would never stop, and that their turn would come at last.

191. Cyrus was now reduced to great perplexity, as time went on and he made no progress against the place. In this distress either some one made the suggestion to him, or he bethought himself of a plan, which he proceeded to put in execution. He placed a portion of his army at the point where the

them, as the Nimrud sculptures show, could have been constructed rapidly. Even if it had been necessary to divide the Gyndes, in order to make it fordable, there would have been no need of entirely dispersing it, and so wasting a whole summer. And if this was the only means by which Cyrus could pass the comparatively small stream of the Diyálah, how did he get across the Tigris?

If we accept the fact of the dispersion, the true explanation would seem to be, that Cyrus had already resolved to attempt the capture of Babylon by the means which he subsequently adopted, and thought it necessary to practise his army in the art of draining off the waters from a stream of moderate size before attempting the far greater work of making the Euphrates fordable. He may not have been aware of the artificial reservoir which rendered his task at Babylon comparatively easy, or not have anticipated the neglect which converted a means of defence to the assailed into a convenience to the assailing party.

It is remarkable that Mr. Grote accepts the narrative of Herodotus as it stands, apparently seeing in it no improbability. At least he offers no explanation of the conduct of Cyrus (Hist. of Greece, vol. iv. pp. 284-5).

[I incline to regard the whole story as a fable, embodying some popular tradition with regard to the origin of the great hydraulic works on the *Diyálah* below the Hamaran hills, where the river has been dammed across to raise the level of the water, and a perfect network of canals have been opened out from it on either side. The principal of these canals to the east, now named *Beladroz* (*Bapápoð* in Theophrastus, and *Baraz rud*, or "hog river," of the Arabs), is apparently of extreme antiquity, the stream having worked itself a bed in the alluvial soil nearly 50 feet below the level of the country. There are fully 360 streams of water derived from the *Diyálah*, including all the branch cuts from the seven great canals. If Cyrus did indeed execute these works, his object must have been to furnish means of irrigation to the country, and such a motive was scarcely likely to have influenced him when he was conducting a hostile expedition against Babylon. Moreover, if he marched upon Babylon by the high road leading from the Persian mountains, he would have had no occasion to cross the *Diyálah* at all. The direct route must have followed the left bank of the river to Opis, near which was the passage of the Tigris.

The name of the river Gyndes is probably derived from the cuneiform *Khudun*, a city and district on the banks of the river adjoining *Hupuska*, which is mentioned in the annals of Sardanapalus. It is at any rate worthy of remark that all the names by which this river has been known in modern times, *Tamerra*, *Shirvan*, *Nahrwan*, and *Diyálah*, are those of cities on its banks, and the same system of nomenclature may very well be supposed to have existed in antiquity.—H. C. R.]